To: Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters

Date: 20 October 2025

Submission on the Behaviour of the [redacted] Party Candidate for Bennelong and His Supporters

I have lived in North Ryde and voted in the Bennelong electorate since 1990. On many election days I have volunteered to support the [redacted]) candidate. This includes attending polling booths and distributing how-to-vote cards to voters.

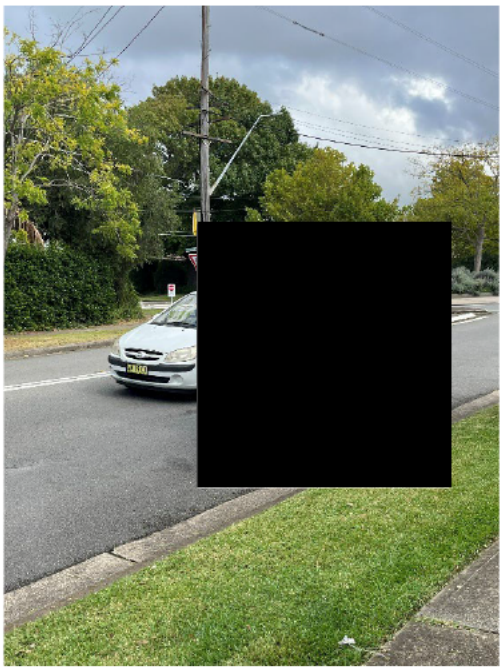
Over many federal, state and local council elections I have got to know volunteers from other political parties. These parties include the [redacted] Party, [redacted] Party, [redacted], [redacted] Party and the [redacted], as well as local independents.

I have recently been more involved with the [redacted] and became a member in 2023. I worked extensively on the re-election campaign for [redacted] during the Federal election in May 2025.

This personal submission highlights my concerns at the behaviours of the [redacted] Party candidate and his representatives. Unlike all past campaigns, their campaign was marked by excess and disregard for electoral laws. In particular, I wish to document that I witnessed the [redacted] Party candidate threatening and bullying an AEC staff member.

Excessive and Dangerous Advertising

A striking difference between the 2025 campaign compared with previous ones was the level of excessive and dangerously positioned advertising. Instead of the usual handful of posters from the main candidates, there was an excessive number of posters for the [redacted] candidate. You could not walk or drive in Bennelong without being confronted with his image.



Where the front garden of a [redacted] supporter might previously have had 1 or 2 posters, there would be 10 or more. While individuals have a right to display as many posters as they wish on their own property, it was distressing to see the [redacted] Party show flagrant disregard for public property.

Among the many examples of potential illegality, the [redacted] Party saturated our roads and streets with:

- Multiple posters mounted on utility poles across the whole of Bennelong.
- Dangerously parked trailers with multiple posters at traffic blind spots. (Midway roundabout exit to Quarry Road, see photo.)

- Distractingly large numbers of posters at important road junctions. (Cnr Lane Cove Road and Coxs Road just one example.)
- Massive (and very expensive) digital overhead hoarding advertisements at the Devlin Street intersection.

This behaviour by the [redacted] Party raises serious questions that the committee should consider:

- Are current electoral laws sufficient to ensure that ordinary voters are only exposed to a moderate and reasonable level of political advertising?
- Are current electoral laws currently being enforced when a party (in this instance the [redacted] Party) shows flagrant disregard for those electoral laws?
- From a road safety perspective, and especially to protect school children, should the dangerous placement of political advertising on roads be considered a traffic or criminal offence?
- How will the true electoral expenditures of all candidates be established so that any breaches of electoral law can be readily identified and made public?

On numerous occasions while talking with friends, neighbours, café staff and shopkeepers, they would say how appalled they were by the [redacted] Party campaign. Unprompted I would be told that they would be voting against the [redacted] Party candidate due to the excessive volume of advertising.

Experiences at Eastwood Pre Polling Booth

I was asked to assist at Eastwood Pre Polling Station, located at the Eastwood Community Baptist Church on First Avenue, Eastwood. I attended on several afternoons towards the end of the campaign.

On my first shift I encountered far larger numbers of [redacted] Party representatives than I have ever seen before, at least 30 to 40. This was highly unusual for a mid-week afternoon before election day. From their branded clothing and merchandise to their materials and banners, it was clear that considerable money was being spent by the Liberal Party campaign.

There were several serious adverse impacts from the [redacted] Party's strategy of intensive resourcing:

- Voters felt overwhelmed by the numbers of [redacted] Party representatives, some of whom would approach voters in a confrontational manner.
- Voters had to walk for 60m past [redacted] Party representatives brandishing posters and attempting to force their electoral material into their hands.
- Other local residents simply walking past were impeded by the volume of [redacted] Party representatives and occasionally were forced onto the road to navigate their way along First Avenue.

With pre-poll voting more popular at this election, there were long queues of voters waiting to enter the booth and wait times exceeded 30 minutes. Despite these voters having already walked past the multiple [redacted] Party representatives, they were had to endure shouted slogans and placards waved by other [redacted] Party representatives.

As there were far fewer [redacted] representatives we focussed on maintaining a quiet and respectful presence towards the front of the queue. We only engaged with voters who appeared interested in speaking with us. These voters often complained to us about the [redacted] Party representatives.

Flouting of Electoral Laws by the [redacted] Party Representatives

A critical requirement for party representatives is to abide by electoral law and follow all instructions from Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) staff. In particular, there is the "6 metre" rule that forbids party representatives from standing with 6 metres of the polling booth entrance. An AEC staff member will advise where this boundary is for the booth in question. Party representatives are also forbidden from standing in close proximity to queuing voters outside this boundary.

In all my years of election volunteering I have never seen such blatant disregard for these electoral laws as that shown by the [redacted] Party representatives. On multiple occasions I witnessed [redacted] Party representatives:

- Standing at the entrance doorway to the polling booth
- Walking up and down the queue of voters and addressing them loudly

Despite frequent reminders and instructions from AEC staff, the [redacted] Party representatives continued to harass the queue of voters each afternoon when I was at Eastwood Pre Poll.

Bullying of AEC Staff by the [redacted] Party Candidate

One incident was truly shocking and revealed the true character of the [redacted] Party candidate. It is worth noting that while his party representatives were acting anti-socially and unprofessionally, he made no attempt to rein them in. In fact, he encouraged them.

At one point he was walking up the line of queuing voters and forcing them to shake his hand. I saw several voters recoil in shock at this tactic. He ignored my requests to set a better example and follow electoral law.

When an AEC official came out to survey the queue I approached him and pointed out the candidate's behaviour. The official was reluctant to intervene as the candidate was accompanied by several larger males wearing [redacted] Party t-shirts. To his credit, the AEC official did approach the candidate and advised him that he had to stop harassing voters and keep his distance from the queue.

The events following the intervention by the AEC official are etched on my mind. The [redacted] Party candidate, who was considerably taller than the AEC official, stood over him and pressed his whole body against the official. His "candidate smile" disappeared and he snarled at the official. He shouted words to the effect that no-one could prevent him talking to voters and accused the AEC official of denying him his democratic rights.

I was shocked to witness this and found myself stepping forward to intervene. I certainly raised my voice and told the [redacted] Party candidate to stop threatening a public official and that I was prepared to call the Police.

I forget what the candidate said to me in return but it was not pleasant. I was then suddenly surrounded by many large and threatening young men shouting at me. They tried to man-handle

me away from their candidate. All were wearing [redacted] Party t-shirts. The situation then calmed down the young men moved away.

There was one final interaction which was very revealing. The [redacted] Party candidate approached me later to apologise for his actions. But with his apology he also said he had told his people to stop targeting me.

Can members of the committee credit that in 2025 in Australia a [redacted] Party candidate would admit to instructing a group of large young men to target and harass representatives of other political parties?

Final Observations

I must stress how these events and experiences are wholly different to any past election. I have stood alongside many [redacted] Party representatives, collaborated with them on logistical matters and enjoyed friendly banter and jokes. I recall a very warm conversation at the end of the 2024 state election with the former Member for Ryde, [redacted].

The majority of the [redacted] Party members in the 2025 election were new faces and seemed very unconnected with local politics. When one of them heard that I ran my own business, he asked if I liked paying tax. I replied that this was how public services and infrastructure were funded and he replied that I must be a Communist. I confess I am old enough to remember when "Communist" was a political insult. I found it curious that a young person in 2025 would consider that a worthwhile response.

During the election I also attended local train stations to promote the [redacted] campaign to commuters. On occasions I witnessed unusual behaviour by [redacted] Party representatives. They would simply stare at their phones and fail to engage with the commuters. None of them were aware of [redacted] Party policies and they seemed to have no understanding of Australian politics.

It is hard to understand why someone would stand for 2 hours at a train station, have no interest or understanding of Australian politics and not be receiving a financial benefit. They were certainly not [redacted] Party volunteers in the traditional sense.

I did also see some female [redacted] Party representatives who seemed apart from the usual [redacted] women I have met. None participated in the aggressive tactics of their male colleagues but instead they stood back and seemed have a subservient role handing them water bottles and snacks.

On election day one such woman stood out. She was plainly dressed and seemed nervous and apprehensive. When I smiled at her and commented on the weather she shook her head and moved away.

I raise these points to address the allegation that the [redacted] Party engaged members of the Exclusive Brethren church to work on their campaign in Bennelong. Having regularly visited and shopped in West Ryde for many years, I am accustomed to occasionally seeing Brethren families. I personally have no problem with them but am aware of various accusations made against their church organisation.

For me it was evident that a large cohort of [redacted] Party representatives in the election campaign were members of the Exclusive Brethren. The large numbers of young men seemed to have no work or study obligations. They all had an air of self-importance and self-righteousness

and were intolerant of anyone whom they disliked. They made no attempt to engage or participate constructively in the electoral process. Their role appeared solely to bully and harass [redacted] supporters and intimidate voters into supporting the [redacted] Party.

Summary of Points for the Committee to Consider

I hope that the committee can understand the concerns of Bennelong voters at the nature of the [redacted] Party campaign and their representatives. Their behaviour was excessive even for a vigorously fought campaign.

The specific concerns I raise in this submission are:

- The effectiveness of campaign expenditure laws and the publication of party funding sources.
- The need for declarations of engaged third parties to support a party's campaign.
- The need for more timely and material penalties for parties not complying with laws for positioning of electoral advertising.
- The need for anti-bullying laws to govern the behaviour of candidates and party representatives at pre-polling and polling stations.
- The need for bullying of AEC staff by candidates and party representatives to be a criminal offence.

I thank the committee for the opportunity to raise these points.

James Smith